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Ada Rovatti

Italian-native Ada Rovatti is making her mark in the jazz scene as a saxophonist, producer, composer, and band leader. Her recent "Sacred Bond" release features her husband, Randy Brecker, performing Ada's original compositions.

Ada was interviewed via Zoom on December 13, 2022 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm at Hamilton College for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm really pleased to have Ada Rovatti with me this afternoon. Welcome.

AR: Well thank you. Thank you for having me.

MR: I'm going to ask you a new question for today. So far today on this Tuesday, what have you done musically that contributes to you making a living in music?

AR: Well unfortunately it's answering email. That's the first thing you do in the morning, just — I just got back from Germany where I recorded the basic track of my new album and I had to add strings, percussion and soloists so this morning was the time to send some of the charts and update of what's going to happen. So that's the first thing — I mean of course in the morning when I get up I put some music on, that always helps, a way to kind of start in a good mood the day, but then there is the kind of haunting task of answering email and business that is not — I mean it helps to kind of moving forward but is not as technical as practicing. I haven't touched my horn yet, but I will.

MR: Is the music that you tend to put on related to the music that you create or do you find that something on the opposite end of the spectrum also works for you?

AR: Definitely on the opposite side of the spectrum. Somehow music, you know I grew up playing classical music. I was a piano player, trained. And at the time I didn't like very much classical music, I was more into English pop. But now I find myself that I — maybe even listen more classical music than jazz, and somehow — it's interesting how the brain it works sometimes, so I listen to music like traditional Irish music with — I love Irish music — and somehow it tricks something that is totally opposite and it just goes in the jazz realm, just go figure how the brain works with like sounds, sound waves, just kind of vitamins for the brain.

MR: Yeah. I found that I think my tastes have sort of gone backwards in that I like music in both jazz and classical sort of where I know where I am in it.

AR: Yeah.

MR: If you know what I mean.

AR: Yeah it's just kind of like you feel at home in a certain way. But you know I just — like it depends also the mood, because there are some times that I cannot listen Coltrane because it's like taking over caffeinated myself. You know I wouldn't be able to relax on a Coltrane CD because my mind goes on kind of not working but you know I hear these things, I analyze, I just discover — oh I didn't notice that he was doing that. So to me it's just like, it's not a way to relax. So sometimes even if I put like Tibetan bells it's more relaxing because you don't have to analyze anything, just the sound, spin one note for three minutes and that's it.

MR: Were your parents, did they contribute to your musical career? Did they want you or force you to take piano lessons?

AR: Well my grandmother was a piano teacher so I think all — my brother, my cousins, we all went through her teaching. The only one who stuck with it was me. So that's how it worked. But I have it, in a certain way, family, like a musical family. My dad plays some piano because his mother played piano. My mother, from her family's side, her great grandfather was a director of an orchestra. And my mom played a little guitar. But I was lucky that I was surrounded by music. Unfortunately not really jazz because that was not — you know just was not part of the way I grew up. I mean the only jazz recording I had, it was Bing Crosby singing Christmas tunes. So that's as far as jazz as I was exposed as a child but I kind of catched up.

MR: You know you said before we were recording that you're really into holiday lights and perhaps that's it, perhaps that planted —

AR: Yeah I know it just makes me happy. I know as a kid I used to stare at light two inches the Christmas tree lights changing color, and I could say, I'm not kidding, I could stay one hour. I was like — there was something magical about it, you know? And so now that they are cheap and they are LED and they don't consume very much I kind of plaster my practice room. Like people that come here it's like, "Wow it's always Christmas here." Yeah.

MR: Did your parents understand when you embraced jazz as a — I'll use the word "passion." Was it a passion for you in high school?

AR: Well we don't ever, you know in Italy everybody's kind of thinking that you know it's a country all the belle canto, the music and the conservatory, the opera — so there has to be music at school. And as a matter of fact it's absolutely not like that. In elementary school we have recorder and choir. In middle school we have the history of music but not actual practicing instruments or anything. And in high school we don't have music. So there's absolutely no music at school. And unless you have parents that are, you know, willing to enroll you in some extracurriculum outside of the school music course you are not exposed to music. I was lucky that my grandmother played piano and, you know, so

somehow I started, through piano I started kind of experimenting, kind of like pop and then my brother started to play guitar, he put the band together and it was a blues band then he convinced me that if I — he wanted a horn section. He convinced me that if I played saxophone I would be popular with boys. So that's the only reason I went into music.

MR: Was he right?

AR: Of course. I find a husband. I highly suggest it for any single out there to pick up an instrument.

MR: Well there you go. You know because later I was going to ask you about advice to up and coming musicians so you could put that on the list.

AR: But you know my parents, they — I have an unusual set of parents. You know they travel all over the world, not the classical Italian parents if somebody can think — my mother was in a national softball team, my father was a professional hunter in Africa and traveled all over the world. So one thing they taught me is just like you have wings, use it. So the freedom, and knowing people, knowing culture just enlarges your mind and grows your heart. So that was the best supporting environment I ever had, and I'm lucky for that.

MR: Nice. Can you recall what your — I assume you had to do an audition of some sort to get the Berklee scholarship. And do you remember what tunes you played?

AR: Ooh. Well unfortunately I started really late to play saxophone because I was at the end of high school. And I started as a baritone player because I thought maybe the chance to get a scholarship were higher and rightfully so. And I followed a two-week course at Berklee, still has a two-week course at Umbria Jazz, the festival in Italy, and that's how I followed, I did two courses and at the end I got a scholarship. It was really a beginning but thanks God they found some kind of — I guess talent hidden somewhere because I barely could play and read. I was kind of, really kind of a beginner. I could hear a lot of stuff and I had facility with technique I guess because coming from classical music and playing piano, so I could hear stuff. I had a good ear. But I was really a beginner. But they bet on me and I think I did okay.

MR: It was a good bet.

AR: Yeah. I hope so.

MR: Was there a bit of academic and culture shock when you went to Boston and Berklee?

AR: Yes but I was craving for that. You know I'm coming from a small town in the north of Italy and you know when I started really playing and I started kind of really kind of loved the environment, I had a million ideas, it was hard to find somebody who was as committed as I was to music. You know the people that want to play or want to play jazz was even smaller. I was lucky there was a little big band but you know there were people that had another job and you know I wanted to practice, play new things every day, and

you know it was lucky if you find somebody once every ten days. So going in an environment where everybody is so driven like I was it was exciting, refreshing and a little overwhelming also because you know the moment I stepped into Berklee I realized how poor a musician I was you know. I was just — man — especially in the summer there were kids that were high school kids that were 14, 15, and they have everything together. They had the tone, the timing, the knowledge. And I was much older than them, I was already 19, 20 because that's when I finished high school I went to Berklee. And I didn't have any of those things. So unfortunately it's one thing that I still paid the toll I think that I didn't have that background of having school, somebody to teach me when I was younger. And I always say when I do master classes at school is that you don't realize how lucky you are. In elementary school you have the chance to pick up instruments. I saw the first saxophone when I was 16 or 17 you know. So you just sat there, and the way you learn when you are younger is much different than when you are already grown up. You know you just absorb in a different way. And I still feel that some basic of my musical puzzle are missing, some of the basics. Because I was already kind of rushing into working, I was already kind of in and out of it. So you know you don't spend, you don't have the freedom of like oh I can practice all day long somebody's going to pay my bills you know. When I started to kind of —

MR: Well it's interesting because Randy explained a bit in our interview about the way both of you work and some of the technology but when you said occasionally you run into things that you still are missing in your music education, can you be specific about that?

AR: Just I swear it's like simple stuff you know. I still feel that sometimes my time is wiggly woggly and just like sometimes my ideas they don't — you know they are simple things that probably for any beginner musician will be the first step that you do it. And I skipped some of the steps because maybe I was, technically I was a little more advanced so I was more going for the idea and then I realized yeah, but I slop it up all the way to the idea so I need to slow down, you know, the metronome hello — is there to be used not as a centerpiece of a table. So a lot of things. But also you know clearly more you study more, you play more, you advance the more you go looking for the little problem and that's where you know the last few years has been — just find what's not working, you know? Because I can enjoy, just flatter myself how can I sound good on that, but that's not the point you know. In this room that's where I want to see where I suck (sorry my French). You know that's where I wanted to see where I messed up things and where I need to be really honest with myself where, you know, where I do the mistake. And I need to take care here. So that's, you know, it's hard to kind of look at yourself and see your flaw and acknowledge them and be willing to change them.

MR: You've got an impressive — I guess we'd call it a discography so far, with your own material and playing on other people's recordings. Do you have a sense of why people call you to play on their recordings?

AR: Well you know wooh, that's a good one. Well you know with Randy yes it's my husband and I'm the wife, but clearly if I couldn't — you know a lot of people assume oh if she's in the Brecker Brothers and plays with him, yes and no. Yes I'm the wife but clearly if I couldn't play I wouldn't be there. And I think he likes the idea that I have my own sounds and of course I would love to sound like Mike but nobody's going to sound like Mike and I don't — I keep trying to practice and be as good as him but I wanted to keep my own identity. So he always said that I have pretty strong sounds and identity and I wanted to keep working on that. I think I have a good attitude towards music, I take everybody every music seriously so any kind of a job that is asked, that I've been asked, I always spend time in order to understand what they want and try to do the best I can so I'm professional and I think I have something to say. I hope so.

MR: I like that, you have something to say. I know that some of the older generation of musicians they used to say well tell a story when you're improvising.

AR: Yeah but I think it's the same the moment we are talking me and you right now is an exchange of question and comments and a little comedy, a little — and the same should be on the bandstand it's just an interaction and you want to be sure that not only the musician gets the interaction but also the audience. I was actually talking today, I was in the car with Randy and saying that sometimes some of the jazz that I hear it sounds like a private conversation between elite musicians. And you know you cannot remember any melody or any — you just don't — I mean I do appreciate that that kind of intellect for music because it's really kind of like intellectual and can — but you know what about the famous music is entertainment? You have also the audience be part of it. If it's just a private talk between just elite musicians, that's bad. So I like to hear the melody, I like that people can just move their head, they just kind of you see that they have a feedback. That's how I get excited and I play better. You know? If it's just between me and my music and a couple of my friends we can just stay in the basement and we'll do the same.

MR: I liked watching, there's a number of videos on YouTube of you in the Brecker Brothers and there's one moment where you're taking sort of an extended solo and I mean this is not a big deal, it's bandstand etiquette, but you turn and you give the band a cue.

AR: Yeah.

MR: Like okay let's move — like I'm done — and then the band moves on. I just love that stuff. And I think people who are in the audience who are really into it, they probably see that.

AR: Yeah I think so, plus I'm Italian, I'm always moving my hands. You know the joke how do you shut up an Italian? You tie their hands behind their back. So I do very good on the stage.

MR: Well how did you develop the altissimo?

AR: Well that's one thing that also I'm still practicing because it's not where it should be or where I would like it to be. But yeah I'm doing like overtones, doing exercises, but sometimes when I get too nervous I tend always to bite a lot of the mouthpiece and that doesn't help the tone and the altissimo register. So that's one thing I'm working, trying to not put so much pressure. And it's a daily thing. Sometimes where I'm more relaxed I can go easy on altissimo and you know be more technical. If I'm nervous forget about it sometimes. I aim for a note and something else comes out. But —

MR: Have you ever experienced the fact that you go for some of those notes in the practice room and you can't get them but when you're surrounded by friendly chords that they seem to come out?

AR: Yeah.

MR: I'm not sure what that's about.

AR: Well you know I — the more I'm getting older I realize that it has to do a lot with confidence. There is something that if you feel at ease with the musicians you don't feel to prove yourself, if you just say I'm here to do what I can do and I do the best and I'll try to have fun. Sometimes everything works better. If you just start to kind of double-guessing yourself, wondering what people might think, getting nervous, that's a recipe for disaster, at least for me. You know sometimes I finish the gig, one of those stressful gigs that you just say you feel you have — like you're trying to impress or at least, I don't know, getting all into the what they're thinking. And I always think oh my God thanks God I'm not a surgeon I would have killed somebody tonight. So at least I can relax on that.

MR: Do you find that, I won't say easier — how is it different if you're soloing over a vamp on one chord rather than playing changes like on a hard bop tune? Is your thought process different?

AR: Well you know it's just with one chord of course it also depends also on the band you are playing with, it's just like a blank, it's a white canvas that you can just go in the direction you want. With one chord and then just like play out, in and out, and just kind of rhythmically — you study, there is a specific form with a specific rhythm and the chords change clearly you have some flexibility of reharmonization and playing in and out but you still have to kind of follow the chords and the form. So it's a different kind of approach. But it's just like, you know, sometimes — one exercise I like to do just to open my ears, you know a lot of people say when you play out what do you think — it's just

like I think it comes down to confidence and just bend the boundaries that we have in our inner ears. You know if you're playing in C, and sometimes I put one of those Aebersold like C7 and the band plays C7. And I keep playing B7 or C#7 or F#7 and these totally out you know, clashing. But if you keep playing against those chords, you're going to realize that your brain little by little easing up, It doesn't hear that much, that dissonance. And as a matter of fact when you go back, in C, it sounds as if you're messing it up. Your brain kind of like suddenly is like what are you playing? And I'm playing C over C. But just that tells you that it's all here, the dissonance. And it's fun to just play in a totally dissonant and go in and out of the chords, it's just the way also to pulling the audience, it's like look at me now, look what I do. And they kind of don't get it but then they feel relaxed when you go back in the key. So it's just a way of teasing your ears, the musician, it's just a game you know.

MR: Oh that's wonderful. No one ever said that exactly like that.

AR: It's a way of teasing your senses, let's put it like that.

MR: Okay. So what constitutes a wrong note in improvisation?

AR: What prompts you?

MR: What — can you play a wrong note when you're improvising?

AR: No. You know.

MR: I can.

AR: Do you mean it? Well you know if you start to think that it's not a wrong note you know. I mean of course you know you land so bad that nobody can follow you, but we played the weekend with it was Dave Kikosky on piano and Alex Claffy on bass and Steve Johnson on drums, and Randy. And on one of Randy's tunes it started with an E flat major. So you know I played a solo and then I finished and I purposely I ended on an E major. And it was E flat major. Beautiful. Kikosky put out the funkiest chord ever and he sounded perfect. So you know, and I on purpose I kind of wanted to land on something out. And the band didn't blink. It just went for it and it sounds the most amazing — and then Kikosky was playing after me and he started with an E major over E flat and he kept going. And it was magic. You know when you have a band like that you are allowed to kind of explore and they kind of hold you like that and even your mistakes when it's like a total mistake, they put something behind you that makes sense that you are not mistaken. You know what I mean?

MR: That's terrific. There was a critic years ago, Whitney Balliet, who said, he called jazz "the sound of surprise."

AR: Yeah it is. You know.

MR: Let me ask you about your composing. There's two tunes that I heard and well I know they're a number of years apart as far as your recordings. One was "Air Drop" and the

other one was "I Lost My Wisdom." And they both have — if my memory serves me they both have a thing where you start out in one tempo and feel, before long you go somewhere else.

AR: Yeah. That's a thing I do in all my tunes there's always a little — little things of surprise, little things that when you expect something happen or is not happening or when you don't expect, you know you expect just smooth sailing for the rest of a tune something else happens to rock you. And I think that musicians at this point, the musicians I'm working with, they know when I bring new tunes they're like oh here we are, what she's doing. And I just like — I don't know maybe I have a little attention disorder. So I like — I don't want to get bored so that's why I always throw a twist in my tunes it's just kind of like oop! And I like to see the reaction of the musician because I remember one drummer told me it's like as soon as you get in the groove and you're thinking I got it, you throw something that I need to just keep an eye on my chart. You know I don't want to sound like you know just do like a cycle that goes from one thing to the other. Like sometimes I write tunes that they sound very organic and then when you analyze the chart it's like oh I didn't realize you moved from 7/8 to da-da-da da-da-da. But your ears doesn't feel it as just a change, a big change or a change of tempo or something like that. Only when you see the chart — that's also sometimes things that — they almost have to see it enough with smooth jazz because I wouldn't call smooth jazz my tunes but they say oh you know I have it, I got it down. And then when they see the music it's like I guess I need to give an extra look to the chart. They sound —

MR: Are your charts complicated? Would you call them complicated?

AR: Yes they are. They don't sound complicated but they are. And I tend, especially in the last couple recordings I started to become very — a little control freak — let's say it like that. I like to write specific things: a bass line, voicing, specific rhythm and bass line, specific bass line through the melody. On the solo do whatever you want. I mean I leave you the freedom of going around. But on the head I want specific things and I have a clear mind. You know I just saw, the recording we did in Germany you know there were a couple of places that the band was like I don't know, did you write this one? It was like no, I want it exactly like that. I don't know if it works, it's not the right key for the bass. No I wanted it — play it the way it's written. And then they were like ha! It actually does work. I was like yeah. I hear it. You know I knew what I wanted. So I was excited that I stuck to my guns.

MR: Do you write at the computer?

AR: Yes. I mean mostly I play piano then if I have some good idea I write notes on a paper and then I may play on a keyboard just to remember better the feelings. But that's one great thing that I had a background in piano because I write everything on a piano. And

somehow I always seek the perfect range for B flat instruments so it's interesting how it works.

MR: If you got a phone call from some group, I know you've done commissions, I saw a thing about a commission you and Randy did. And if they ask you to write something and they don't give you any guidelines for instrumentation. Is there something you do to try to inspire something to get started?

AR: Well the tune should already give me some input but usually I ask, you know, if they want a full horn section or just some — how many horns — just to have an idea of the sounds they want. And I ask, you know, do you hear kind of like Tower of Power or just kind of more kind of like traditional writing or — just to have an idea of what they want. But it happens sometimes that I wrote something that I thought was good and they didn't went for it. You know. It's normal. They say well it's just — you know I was thinking of a little more traditional. Okay. You know sometimes also people that commission, they don't have a clear idea so they kind of, you write something and then you realize that they couldn't word out what they want but then they write and they say that's not what I want. Okay, so you know it's like okay I need to go to the other direction. And it happens. Or sometimes it happens that, you know, they don't tell you anything and they hear, it was like I would have never have thought to — thinking about some horn section or some arrangement like that, but I love it. So go figure.

MR: I would imagine sometimes you'd have something that's already partly written and you can go ahh — I might be able to use this thing that's been floating around.

AR: Well that's when I do it for my own tunes because I have like bars here — I have books and books of little ideas and a computer filled with like logic file with three million tunes ideas. But for other people usually I just go fresh. I enter the tune as a new thing so what I hear. And you know there are clearly some gimmick that I notice that I use harmonically-wise or rhythmically that I notice like I always do some of this. But maybe it's my trademark.

MR: Yeah. That's style right there.

AR: Yeah. Who knows?

MR: Well I just noticed I saw your people that you've played with — I think you and I have something in common that we both played behind Aretha Franklin.

AR: Aha. That was — I still think of as one of the best day of my life. Because when I started to play saxophone the first gig I had was I played the horn for one month and we played with this little local band — I cannot tell you the level we were. And one girl wanted to sing "Respect." I cannot tell you how it came out but you know. And who knew that the little girl playing in that funky band back in Italy in the middle of nowhere years later

will be at the Kennedy Center behind the real deal. That was one day that I said, "Well, Ada you didn't mess up too much in your life."

MR: Was that the event that honored Carole King?

AR: No. I think it was organized for the Monk Institute. It was something like that. And we were asked — you know I was one of the guests and was supposed to play the day after — we arrived early the day before to do rehearsal and like out of nowhere they asked will you be willing to be in the horn section with Aretha Franklin and I was like uh yes! Look at me. I was thrilled. And I mean that's massive. You know it's funny because the same night we had performed also with Herbie Hancock and a bunch of other superstars, but Aretha, you know that's another thing. And I remember before going on stage I was really next to her and it was just like this woman, you know the amount of talent, the goose bumps this woman gave me throughout my life is just like thank you.

MR: I had a hard time — she played here at our college and I was in the sax section and I had a hard time not watching — I couldn't watch her because —

AR: Yeah you have to look at the music.

MR: Yeah, we were sort of sight reading you know and —

AR: That's the same you know. You know when they brought the charts they just say, "Okay, today she doesn't want to do it in this key so at A you have to transpose da-da-da-da. So we were sight reading and transposing at the same time. So it was kind of like okay we made it through. I was so nervous in looking at the charts that you know you can see I have some picture of me with this kind of scared look like a pure panic mode. But I still have the picture with her so that's what matters.

MR: Wonderful. You know in a perfect world the idea of the woman jazz musician wouldn't be an issue. Like you're a jazz musician. But I guess we're not at that point yet. Have you experienced not getting work that you thought you would have — how do I phrase this? Do you think you've lost work because you are a woman jazz musician?

AR: Well I have mixed feelings about all these movements about you know women. Because yes we have been discriminated for a long time. But okay let's start with the fact yes, we are still seen as kind of like, you know, the beard woman. The circus little gimmick. So, and you know, so festivals say, "Hey we already have a female saxophone player so we cannot hire you." It's like, "Yeah but you have 15 male saxophone players." So sometimes we are still seen as something like a token. At the festivals they need to have a certain amount of women so let's get one saxophone player, one trumpet. So we are not still kind of just — yeah the other female saxophone player, she's doing that and I'm doing something else. So even if we are doing the same things we are two different entities playing our own things. Nobody would have thought about saying oh we have Stan Getz and da-da-da-da on it. But we still pay that. The same for magazines, the same

for reviews, the same for a lot of things. Of course some counterpoints say yeah but you know a lot of times in private events they want a girl playing saxophone because it's cool. Yeah but you know it's just like it's minimal. You know you still need to be able to perform you know. So you know, and all the other things it's like on the other side just to kind of like I don't know how to straight out the way I'm thinking you know. I found that sometimes you know there is a little too much fear of saying anything these days about women. I did — I grew up with one brother and two cousins so I was kind of I would wrestle them and I never thought a difference between you know, the gender. And when, especially the last couple of years I remember I did a big band gig and the band leader told the main musicians how to dress. And then it was me and another female and he said, "I would never dare to tell you what to wear." And I thought it was just like Jesus are we like that that we are afraid to even talk about it or just everybody is so, now, like afraid to say half the things — nobody can do a compliment to a woman out of afraid that he's going to be sued or stuff like that. And I find it's just a little too far you know. So I remember that I sent back to everyone — I'm twisted, sorry — but I sent to everyone in the big band a big picture of a tassel. A tassel.

MR: A tassel. Okay.

AR: And I say, "I was thinking to wear this, is it okay?" You know. Just kind of like okay, loosen up. It's okay. Maybe it's my Italian way, I'm a little right on your face about things you know. And I'm pro-women, pro-Me Too movement but let's also not forget that the camaraderism of a big band, of playing together, of just doing a funny comment. Don't be afraid. If somebody say, "Oh you cut your hair, you look great." "Thank you." Or "You're wearing that one, you look great in that dress." "Thank you." You know? Just let's not bring it right away — you know I've done scenarios that men, they're looking at their shoes now. They don't even want to interact out of fear of being out of line as they call it. Yes, we have a long way to go, there is a lot of messed up things. But you know I want to play music. I don't want to just be bombarded of not the rest of the band talking to me out of fear that, you know, they are not politically correct. That's my other side. So probably I'm going to get trashed by a lot of women.

MR: Well said.

AR: You know it's both ways. You know if I don't get respect by a man I know how to put them in their place. You know? And it happened that I lost some gigs because I was a female and I was not — but I also say that you know I lost those, so the hardest time I had unfortunately is with women, other women musicians. I noticed that I have great female musicians that I'm friends with and we really think alike and we are really kind of mellow, we do our job. But you know a lot of hard time I had on a bandstand I had, I

would say more hard time with women than with men, believe it or not. And it is unfortunate because I think you know helping each other would make a big difference.

MR: Thank you for that. Do you know Rossano Sportiello?

AR: Yes. Actually we are coming from almost the same area. We grew up ten minutes apart.

MR: Oh my.

AR: You know, and we knew them from Italy. It's great.

MR: He's played up here numerous times. And I wanted to read something he said and it's just an excerpt but he stated this. He was talking about his formative years in Milan and his fellow musicians. He said, "We felt that the way some American musicians played jazz was really special. That that was the right way. So every time we heard one of these musicians playing we heard that there was something superior. So what happened was that when we would play gigs with my Milanese colleagues and one of us would play very well, the most beautiful compliment that we could tell each other was tonight you sounded like an American.

AR: Yeah. That was like that, yeah. And well, and as a female going back to the previous, they would say you sound like a man. So that was another compliment I would get in Italy. You sound like a man, and you sound like an American. So the first one never sat well with me I have to say. You know?

MR: I see.

AR: But yeah we always looked up to — jazz is a music that was born here so we found that America could have authenticity. And we would just kind of like try to copy. But I think this day, at this point it's global music. Because if you close your eyes you wouldn't think it is like some musician from New Orleans and maybe it's a little younger from Taiwan. You know? And sometimes we just don't — we arrive at the level that you know there are great musicians everywhere and if it was a blindfold test a lot of people won't know who is their ethnicity, where they're from, and their gender.

MR: And it's interesting and a bit ironic that jazz was thought of as an art form first in Europe, not here. People did scholarly writing about it and all that kind of thing.

AR: Yeah it was more appreciated. Also it has to do also with racism here in this country and in Europe. Just the way also I remember I grew up I was always kind of interested about when a musician would come and tour in Italy it was like a black musician it was like kind of cool. It was like there was not — you add something even more exotic and more interesting. So I think that they didn't have to deal with the racism that there was here. And it just really is an art form. I think that's when Europe got it right right away. It was an art form. Here it took a little longer to be fully appreciated.

MR: Yes. But at the same time as you mentioned earlier, it behooves it to have an entertainment aspect to it also.

AR: Um hum.

MR: Otherwise, sometimes you hear, there's a phrase that has gone around like jazz is America's classical music. And some people — no we don't need it to be America's classical music. Just let it be jazz.

AR: Yeah no that's true. Because there is American classical music. They are two different things. There are plenty of classical. I mean I do understand like when they try to mean it like in saying that it's just like the root word. We, in Europe there's classical music here, the American classical music, but no. Just let it be jazz.

MR: So it seems that you and Randy have found a way, and I suppose this maybe is just news to me, that there is technology now that you can exchange with people with sound files and okay this song needs a solo. So they send you — can you explain this process to me?

AR: Yes. We get contacted to I would say put a solo or a horn arrangement or anything, and they just send sometimes just an MP3 if it's already made a good mix. Sometimes we tend to ask for a different .WAV file so we can do our own mix to hear better the drums or whatever. And we just kind of — they send the charts, I map out the charts and record it. Sometimes they send already the Pro Tools files so it's easy maybe to upload it. Sometimes it's just the MP3 of the .WAV file and I'm the technician in the household. So I set up all the sessions for him, and then take a few takes, you know, clean it up if he's doing a horn section he lays down all his parts and clean it up. And then I add my own parts and align with him just to be sure it's nice and tight. And that's it you know. It's kind of a tailoring kind of job. And sometimes you send a couple, you know two or three solos just to be sure, so whoever produced the track hopefully one of the tracks will envision what they are looking for. You know, it happens sometimes they cut themselves a track and use half of one and half the other, but usually you know we send something that is already fluent and had a kind of a nice, you know, little speech. A little talk. A little story. You know? Because sometimes it happens that people that they cut themselves and it's like oops, that was not a good cut. You know as a musician you know where you're going and we recognize our little story and then if somebody cut it and put half and half you say that's not where I was going for. So it's interesting how we kind of know.

MR: Yeah we had said that earlier that we can do this, but should we? You can pass on this question if you'd like but it's not a music question but I'm curious when people like yourself relocate to the United States and observe our political and social issues what do you think about it?

AR: Oy. That's the answer right there. Well especially from Italy where it's well known to have a messed up political situation, nothing stands more than a couple of months. We had from Berlusconi to a porn star in the politic world, I don't know if you know a few

years ago. So we had really like a lot of buffoon and circus character. Coming here, and if I am shocked — I was shocked to see what was happening here politically that tells you a lot. I think that all the world was pretty shocked to see — I mean I'm pretty open about my political view. I'm definitely not a Trumpist, let's put it like that. And I was totally shocked that the country like the United States — you see I grew up and I know that all my fellow European or all over the world, we always grew up looking at the United States like the best of the best. They have the best music, the best movies, the best everything was just like portrayed. We grew up looking at the American movies — it gave us an idea of the American lifestyle so we always looked up. And then coming here and see all these kind of like different sided I guess was always hidden under the rock but then suddenly it came out with the political — you know we didn't growing up there was never showing about racism in a certain way. You saw it as maybe something in the past — maybe like but not something that when I moved here I was shocked about the poverty, all the problems of a beautiful country because I'm going to be always thankful about this country, welcomed me and I had a lot of opportunity. But there was a lot of things that unfortunately just in the last few years they really came out under the rock really. A lot of hatred, racism, you know. So it's kind of sad and hopefully we'll be more and more recognized and put under the lights and just do something about it. I think yes a lot of it was done from the last hundred years but there is still a lot to go you know. And the way when I was raised in Italy we didn't have a vision of America like that. Definitely.

MR: Well we probably have an incorrect vision of Italy because we see in ads and in tours, you know take a tour of the best parts of Italy. So if we were to relocate to somewhere in Italy we probably —

AR: Yeah. Every country sees the downside. Of course we want to portray the best of us. It's like when you go on a date app — you want to put your best picture and your best characteristics. You know? So I think every country — I mean we have — right now we have a very bad economical situation. Kind of similar to what it was here a few years — a couple of years ago with the Republican — not Republican, we'll say with Trump. But so right now, you know we have a lot of poverty and unfortunately we have also a lot of racists now, one thing that was pretty new to Italy. Because when I grew up okay we didn't have so much of a multi-cultural life. But every time I go back it's a lot of things change and didn't change for the best unfortunately.

MR: Well I'll lighten up a little bit. I don't usually ask people about their gear, but I had a thing this morning I had to play tenor and I reminded myself what a lousy horn I have. Can you tell me what sax and mouthpiece you use?

AR: Yes. On the tenor I have a P. Mauriat. I'm endorsed by the company and I met him probably 15 years ago at one of the JEN conferences and I tried them and I really really dig them right away. And I have a nice Mark VI also. But it's a beautiful one, somebody bought it, used it for a month, put it away and sold it to me 50 years later or something like that, or 40 years later. But as I always say it's "flarp." It's flarp. It's flat and sharp. So on the palm key you have to do so much movement from one note to the other, you're just quite never there. You know great sound but man, how much work. And a lot of times I don't want to do a gig wondering how you're going to land and moving so much. So that's — and also the traveling I did a trip that they smashed my case so after that one I was approached around the same time by P. Mauriat and I thought they were great. So I started to kind of play them and to tell you the truth I've really never — I once in a while pull out my Mark VI just for the fun of it but I always play P. Mauriat. And the mouthpiece I'm playing a Rafael Navarro mouthpiece and I've been playing it for five years and I've really, really enjoyed them. And on the soprano I have a Keilwerth that was given to me by Michael years ago. I still have three herniated discs in my neck because of playing saxophone. So for a while I couldn't play the tenor, I couldn't put any weight. And I didn't have a soprano. So you know he had probably a stack of like hundreds of saxophones and he just gave me this beautiful Keilwerth and the mouthpiece is a prototype I think a Louis — what's the name Louis? They are Belgium. I don't remember the name. It is metal. But you know I keep changing, I play also Selmer sometimes mouthpiece. And you know so far I am happy. But it's always some gigs you just kind of like oh I'm going to throw away everything out you know and then the week after it's like I love it. So I think it's a struggle of mouthpiece, reeds, I use Vandoren reeds, ZZ, and this one has been pretty constant in my career.

MR: They're getting more expensive as the time goes by.

AR: I know.

MR: Well what isn't?

AR: Only the gigs get paid less or stay the same.

MR: Maria Schneider made a comment. She was talking about young people and learning music and being obsessed with it. And I'm sort of paraphrasing here but she said you have to have other interests too. You have to live life in order to write meaningful music. Which brings me to your website and you said the things — you listed the things that were of interest to you, and it was a fairly long list but I'm just going to bring up, I've never seen this combination of interests before: elephants, paranormal and Nutella.

AR: I think that totally fits.

MR: Well you'd better explain that.

AR: No, and probably I mean the results of craft and sewing, I'm into sewing these days. Well elephant is just all of his — maybe because as a kid one of my nicknames was Dumbo because I have big ears. Thank you to my brother again and my cousin for lifting me from my ears. And there was something about the elephant, just some kind of melancholic characteristic, their memory. So I always associate with elephants. And as a matter of fact my record label logo has an elephant that my dad drew.

MR: Elefunk band, right?

AR: Elefunk band also was a logo that my dad drew it, and then when you say paranormal I love everything about paranormal. I mean yeah I'm a skeptic/believer. So I go from one opposite to the other. It's just like I like to — anything paranormal — it can go from ghosts or afterlife, aliens, to just the capacity of the brain. I think that we have an amazing capacity of the brain and we use just three, four percent. Imagine what we can do if we just use one percent more. I'm asking just for the one percent, it's not very much. Daily. But you know I totally agree with Maria Schneider. I think that my problem is that I have way too many hobbies and I'm always eager to learn — my mode is like learn one thing a day, that could be any formation or words or some things. It's like I feel I'm a sponge I have so much to learn and not enough time. I love sewing. I picked up doing it during the pandemic and it kind of told me to — you know when you sew you have to think it backwards and inside out. So you just really kind of, you can apply the same technique into a problem. I mean I suffer anxiety and depression and a bunch of other things so being able to approach one problem backwards and inside out it can — and the same for I found out that when I sew I'm thinking about musical pattern. And sometimes I'm sewing and I have to stop and write a succession of notes and patterns, and then I use it later. That tells the brain how — you know you wonder how they are connected to things. So unfortunately I have too many hobbies, too much curiosity, I always ask a million question of how things work — on the street like a truck dumping things. Just like I'm always — I think that when you are on the bandstand all these little details and information might come out in a certain way as a connection as kind of like little hubs going from one section to the other. Right?

MR: Indeed. And it makes for great conversation, I'll say that.

AR: I always have something bizarre to say.

MR: Well this has been a true pleasure.

AR: Oh thank you.

MR: I hope I cross paths with you and Randy sometime in the future.

AR: Definitely I would love to, and play together.

MR: Yeah.

AR: I'll bring some Nutella.

MR: What's the very next thing that's going to happen performance-wise for you?

AR: Well I have a couple of things in the next couple of weeks but then we are off on a jazz cruise at the beginning of January. So that's going to be exciting. And that's going to be fun.

MR: Do you bring your own rhythm section or do they pair you up with — ?

AR: Well sometimes we can go with our band. Some other times they pair us with different — this year I think both me and Randy we're going to do some of the big band stuff and then they're going to pair with different bands. But so that's going to be exciting so I have to polish my doublings that are rusting somewhere and catching dust.

MR: Well you mentioned the vacuum cleaner before we started to just get the vacuum out.

AR: Yes. You know suck everything out of it. Yeah we were saying that sometimes I'd rather vacuum than practice. Unfortunately I'm good to find multiple tasking, whatever but practicing I think is a problem that a lot of musicians can relate to.

MR: Well thank you very much, it's been a pleasure.

AR: Thank you.

MR: I'll pause us and then we'll say good-bye.

AR: Okay.